

PART 2 OF 4 - SECTION TWO: POEMS

12TH HSC ENGLISH

MAHARASHTRA BOARD

2.1 Song of the Open Road, by Walt Whitman

Summary

"Song of the Open Road" by Walt Whitman is an inspirational poem celebrating the freedom and possibilities of life. The speaker views life as a journey on an open road, filled with opportunities for self-discovery and growth. He invites readers to break free from societal constraints, embrace the beauty of nature, and embark on a path of adventure and self-reliance. The poem encourages optimism, independence and a joyful spirit, suggesting that happiness lies in the journey itself, rather than a specific destination.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*Afoot and light-hearted I take to the open road,
Healthy, free, the world before me,
The long brown path before me leading wherever I choose.*

- The poet begins by expressing his excitement and readiness to embark on a journey. "Afoot and light-hearted" suggests that he is travelling on foot and is full of joy and optimism.
- "The long brown path" symbolises the open road, representing life's journey and the opportunities ahead.
- He emphasises his freedom and self-determination, as the road leads him wherever he chooses to go.

Stanza 2

*Henceforth I ask not
Henceforth I whimper
Strong and content I tr*

- The poet rejects the fortune, emphasising is his own good
- "I whimper no more" .
- He expresses a sen with a positive attitude.

Stanza 3

*The earth, that is suffi
I do not want the const
I know they suffice for*

- "The earth, that is su e, tangible things in
- He dismisses the de ellations, implying that
- The stanza conveys mmediate world, rather

Stanza 4

*Still here I carry my old delicious burdens,
I carry them, men and women, I carry them with me wherever I go,
I swear it is impossible for me to get rid of them,
I am filled with them, and I will fill them in return.*

- The "old delicious burdens" refer to the poet's experiences, memories and relationships.
- He acknowledges that these experiences, both pleasant and burdensome, shape his identity and accompany him on his journey.
- The phrase "I will fill them in return" suggests that life is a continuous exchange of experiences, emotions and interactions with others.

Poetic Appreciation

About the Poem, Poet and Title

The poem 'Song of the Open Road' is written by the American poet Walt Whitman (1819-1892), a poet, essayist and journalist known as "The Father of Free Verse." His major literary works include 'Leaves of Grass' and 'O Captain! My Captain'. This poem is taken from 'Leaves of Grass' and is a blend of self-awareness, free will and tenderness of heart. The title is suggestive: "Song" and "Open Road" together evoke happiness and freedom, while "road" carries multiple meanings, signifying mobility, a fresh start, and the journey of life.

Theme

Freedom, the joy of a readers to be true to their responsibilities.

. The poet encourages so being aware of their

Poetic Style

As the poet is a master of varied line lengths and the use of alliteration, metaphor, and imagery adds to its beauty.

lar stanzas, varied line f figures of speech like ' and 'long brown path'

Language and Poetic

The poem is written in fixed rhyme scheme of speech like metaphor, personification

in free verse, it has no rhyme scheme, along with figures of

Special Features

- Free verse structure
- Irregular stanzas

- Irregular line and stanza lengths symbolising life's complexities
- Vivid imagery throughout the poem

Message

The poem teaches us to be optimistic and happy. It encourages us to enjoy life in a healthy, free world and motivates us to fill our hearts with immense pleasure.

Opinion

This poem is appreciated for carrying the theme of freedom and the joy of life. It is full of optimism and teaches readers to enjoy the immense pleasure that life offers.

2.2 Indian Weavers, by Sarojini Naidu

Summary

"Indian Weavers" by Sarojini Naidu highlights the different stages of human life through the metaphor of the work done by Indian weavers at different times of the day. The poem is divided into three stanzas, each depicting a distinct phase of life, birth, marriage and death, represented by the colours and types of garments being woven. The weavers symbolise life's journey from the joy of birth to the solemnity of death.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*Weavers, weaving at break of day,
Why do you weave a garment so gay?
Blue as the wing of a halcyon wild,
We weave the robes of a new-born child.*

- Time: the weavers are working at break of day, symbolising the beginning of life.
- Question: the poet asks why they are weaving a "garment so gay", indicating a cheerful, vibrant fabric.
- Answer: the weavers reply that they are creating "robes of a newborn child", representing the innocence and joy associated with birth.
- Imagery: the colour blue is compared to the wing of a halcyon (kingfisher), a symbol of calmness, beauty and new beginnings.
- Symbolism: this stanza represents the journey from youth to adulthood, symbolising the transition from innocence to experience and happiness.

Stanza 2

*Weavers, weaving at f
Why do you weave a
Like the plumes of a p
We weave the marriag*

- Time: the weavers are working at f
- Question: the poet asks why do you weave a
- Answer: the weavers reply that they are creating Like the plumes of a p
- Imagery: the colours are compared to the plumes of a peacock, representing grandeur, festivity and beauty.
- Symbolism: this stanza represents the journey from youth to adulthood, symbolising the transition from innocence to experience and happiness.

Stanza 3

*Weavers, weaving solemn and still,
Why do you weave in the moonlight chill?
White as a feather and white as a cloud,
We weave a dead man's funeral shroud.*

- Time: the weavers are now working in the moonlight chill, symbolising the end of life.
- Question: the poet asks why they are weaving in such a solemn and still manner, reflecting a sombre mood.
- Answer: the weavers respond that they are making a "dead man's funeral shroud", a garment used to cover the deceased.
- Imagery: the colour white is compared to a feather and a cloud, symbolising purity, peace and the finality of death.
- Symbolism: this stanza represents the third stage of life, death, signifying the end of life's journey and the return to eternal peace.

Poetic Appreciation

About the Poem, Poet and Title

The poem "Indian Weavers" focuses on the Indian artisans, the weavers. The adjective "Indian" in the title is used with a definite purpose, appreciating the work of Indian weavers, and is apt and suitable. The poetess, Sarojini Naidu, was a political activist and the first Indian woman to become President of the Indian National Congress. She later became an to hold the office of Governor, and is known

Theme

The poem depicts weavers, symbolising three parts of life, respectively.

ing, evening and night, of life, respectively.

Poetic Style

The poem consists of three stanzas, each stanza representing a different stage of life. Regular rhyme and structure.

full of symbolism, with imagery and death (old age).

Language and Poetic Devices

The poem has a conversational tone. The weaver replies. It follows a simple structure. 'chill moonlight' enriches the imagery. Symbol and interrogation.

at he is doing, and the fall of day', 'fall of night' and death, simile, metaphor,

Special Features

- Rich use of symbolism throughout the poem
- Regular rhyme and structure
- Depiction of the three stages of human life
- Rich imagery
- The poem can be sung as a song

Message

- Life is like a garment woven of various colours of happiness and sorrow.
- Just as there are three times of day, there are three stages of human life that everyone must go through.
- Life begins with joy, hope, aspiration and happiness; runs through action, adventure, progress, struggle and achievement; and ends with sorrow, grief and sadness.

Opinion

The symbolism in the poem is worth appreciating. The times of day symbolising the stages of life, and the various colours symbolising the various stages of life, are noteworthy. The poem itself is a fabric intertwined perfectly.

2.3 The Inchcape Rock, by Robert Southey

Summary

The poem revolves around the Inchcape Rock, a dangerous reef off the coast of Scotland. A benevolent Abbot placed a bell on the rock so sailors could hear it during storms and avoid it. However, a wicked pirate named Sir Ralph the Rover, driven by jealousy and malice, removes the bell, causing it to sink. Eventually, Sir Ralph himself perishes when his ship crashes into the same rock during a storm, because the guiding bell is no longer there.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*No stir in the air, no stir in the sea,
The ship was still as she could be;
Her sails from heaven received no motion,
Her keel was steady in the ocean.*

- The poem begins with a calm, serene description of the sea: there is no wind, and the sea is perfectly still.
- The ship lies motionless, with its sails hanging limp and the keel stable in the water, creating a sense of peace that contrasts with the sinister events to follow.

Stanza 2

*Without either sign or
The waves flow'd over
So little they rose, so li
They did not move the*

- The Inchcape Rock i
- A bell, the Inchcape foreshadowing the b

sea.
es do not disturb it,

Stanza 3

*The Abbot of Aberbrot
Had placed that bell o
On a buoy in the storm;
And over the waves its*

- The benevolent Abb storms.
- Attached to a buoy, t saved countless live

idden reef during
. The Abbot's kindness

Stanza 4

*When the Rock was hid by the surge's swell,
The mariners heard the warning bell;
And then they knew the perilous Rock,
And blest the Abbot of Aberbrothok.*

- During storms, when the rock was submerged, sailors relied on the bell to identify the danger.
- They blessed the Abbot for his thoughtful gesture, which helped them navigate safely.

Stanza 5

*The Sun in heaven was shining gay,
All things were joyful on that day;
The sea-birds scream'd as they wheel'd round,
And there was joyance in their sound.*

- On a bright, cheerful day, the atmosphere is full of life and happiness.
- Even the sea birds seem to cry out in joy, creating a stark contrast to the dark actions about to unfold.

Stanza 6

*The buoy of the Inchcape Bell was seen,
A darker speck on the ocean green;
Sir Ralph the Rover walk'd his deck,
And he fix'd his eye on the darker speck.*

- The buoy appears a
- The pirate Sir Ralph remove it.

Stanza 7

*He felt the cheering po
It made him whistle, it
His heart was mirthful
But the Rover's mirth*

- Although spring brin
- His cheerfulness ste ng harm, and his evil intentions are soon r

Stanza 8

*His eye was on the Inc
Quoth he, "My men, p*

*And row me to the Inchcape Rock,
And I'll plague the Abbot of Aberbrothok."*

- Sir Ralph orders his crew to row to the Inchcape Rock, expressing his intention to trouble the kind Abbot by removing the warning bell, driven by malice and jealousy.

Stanza 9

*The boat is lower'd, the boatmen row,
And to the Inchcape Rock they go;
Sir Ralph bent over from the boat,
And he cut the bell from the Inchcape float.*

- The boat is lowered and the men row to the rock. Sir Ralph himself cuts the bell from the buoy, ensuring it sinks and removing the warning system entirely.

Stanza 10

*Down sunk the bell with a gurgling sound,
The bubbles rose and burst around;
Quoth Sir Ralph, "The next who comes to the Rock,
Won't bless the Abbot of Aberbrothok."*

- As the bell sinks with a gurgling sound and bubbles, Sir Ralph mockingly remarks that future sailors will no longer bless the Abbot, since the warning bell is gone.

Stanza 11

*Sir Ralph the Rover sa
He scour'd the seas fo
And now grown rich wi
He steers his course f*

- Sir Ralph continues Scotland, where he

lly deciding to return to

Stanza 12

*So thick a haze o'ersp
They cannot see the s
The wind hath blown a
At evening it hath died*

- As his ship nears Sc strong, dies down by

sky and the wind, once

Stanza 13

*On the deck the Rover takes his stand,
So dark it is they see no land.
Quoth Sir Ralph, "It will be lighter soon,
For there is the dawn of the rising Moon."*

- Sir Ralph stands on the deck, unable to see land due to the darkness and fog, and tries to reassure himself and his crew that moonrise will soon provide light.

Stanza 14

*"Canst hear," said one, "the breakers roar?
For yonder, methinks, should be the shore;
Now where we are I cannot tell,
But I wish we could hear the Inchcape Bell."*

- A crew member hears waves breaking against the shore, indicating they are near land, but they are uncertain of their exact position and wish for the guidance of the bell Sir Ralph removed.

Stanza 15

*They hear no sound, the swell is strong;
Though the wind hath fallen, they drift along,
Till the vessel strikes with a shivering shock,
"O Christ! It is the Inchcape Rock!"*

- The crew is helpless
Rock, the very dang
- ly into the Inchcape

Stanza 16

*Sir Ralph the Rover to
He curs'd himself in hi
The waves rush in on
The ship is sinking be*

- Realising his fatal mi
ship, sealing his trag
- the waves flood the

Stanza 17

*But even in his dying f
One dreadful sound c*

*A sound as if with the Inchcape Bell,
The Devil below was ringing his knell.*

- In his final moments, Sir Ralph imagines hearing the bell ringing from the depths of the sea, as though the Devil is tolling it to announce his doom, a supernatural touch that underlines the poem's moral that evil deeds ultimately lead to punishment.

Moral of the Poem: The poem teaches that wickedness and malice ultimately lead to self-destruction. Sir Ralph's actions not only harmed others but also brought about his own downfall.

Poetic Appreciation

Title of the Poem

The title is directly related to the theme of the poem. 'The Inchcape Rock' is a sandstone reef on the east coast of Angus, Scotland, and is the same rock on which the story of the ballad takes place.

Poet and the Theme

The poem is written by the British poet Robert Southey, who was Poet Laureate of England from 1813 to 1843. Some of his other popular poems for school children include 'The Scholar', 'The Battle of Blenheim' and 'Bishop Hatto'. It is basically the story of an Abbot of Aberbrothok and a villainous character, Sir Ralph the Rover. The Abbot installs the bell on the Inchcape Rock to help mariners, while Sir Ralph, envious of the Abbot being blessed by the people, cuts the bell down in anger, only to later be caught in danger himself and unable to save his own ship as a result.

Poetic Style

The poem is a ballad excitement in the read archaic words, and figu

of events that creates
n of events, the use of

Language and Poetic

The language of the b rhyme scheme (a-a, b- figures of speech make

aic phrasing, a regular
. The generous use of

Special Features

Very few poets, such a one of the masterpiece to both adults and child

'The Inchcape Rock' is
egendary story appeals

Message

The poem teaches us appreciate the good de

It also teaches us to

Opinion

Ballads like this one, told as inspiring stories rooted in history, are always enjoyable, and this is one that stands out. Its central message, that those who set traps for others often fall into them, is aptly summed up in the saying: evil digs a pit for others but falls into the same.

2.4 Have You Earned Your Tomorrow, by Edgar Guest

Summary

"Have You Earned Your Tomorrow" by Edgar Guest is a reflective poem that urges readers to introspect on their daily actions and their impact on others. It poses a series of questions about kindness, empathy and selflessness, emphasising that life is fleeting and that the way we treat others determines whether we deserve another day. The poem encourages readers to lead lives of purpose, compassion and service, reminding them that the future is shaped by their present actions.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*Is anybody happier because you passed his way?
Does anyone remember that you spoke to him today?
This day is almost over, and its toiling time is through;
Is there anyone to utter now a kindly word of you?*

- The poet opens with a rhetorical question, asking if anyone's life has improved because of the reader's actions.
- "Is anybody happier because you passed his way?" prompts readers to consider whether their presence has brought joy or comfort to others.
- "Does anyone remember that you spoke to him today?" highlights the importance of simple, thoughtful interactions like a kin
- The stanza reflects o may reflect on whether their actions
- It emphasises that o sion on others.

Stanza 2

*Did you give a cheerful
Or a churlish sort of "H
Were you selfish pure
Or is someone mighty*

- The poet asks wheth indifference.
- "Did you give a chee s in everyday interactions.
- "Or a churlish sort of n casual greetings carry emotional weig
- The poet challenges an act of kindness that made someone feel
- The stanza emphasi e impact.

Stanza 3

*Can you say tonight, in parting with the day that's slipping fast,
That you helped a single brother of the many that you passed?
Is a single heart rejoicing over what you did or said;
Does the man whose hopes were fading now with courage look ahead?*

- The stanza shifts to introspection at day's end, asking whether the reader can honestly say they helped someone in need.
- "Can you say tonight... that you helped a single brother?" highlights the importance of offering support to others.
- The poet asks if any single heart is happier or more hopeful because of the reader's actions or words.
- "Does the man whose hopes were fading now with courage look ahead?" suggests that acts of kindness can restore hope and inspire courage.
- This stanza reinforces the theme of compassion and selflessness.

Stanza 4

*Did you waste the day, or lose it? Was it well or sorely spent?
Did you leave a trail of kindness or a scar of discontent?
As you close your eyes in slumber, do you think that God would say,
"You have earned one more tomorrow by the work you did today"?*

- The final stanza asks whether the reader used the day wisely or wasted it on trivial or selfish pursuits.
- "Did you leave a trail of kindness or a scar of discontent?" suggests that a life of good actions, urging readers to reflect on their choices.
- The poet prompts readers to consider how they would judge their own actions favourably.
- The closing line, "Do you think that God would say, 'You have earned one more tomorrow by the work you did today'?" suggests that a life of purpose and service is rewarded.
- This stanza is a powerful reminder to live with purpose and compassion.

Poetic Appreciation

About the Poem, Poet

"Have You Earned Your Tomorrow" is a poem by Rabindranath Tagore. It is a reflection on the value of time and the importance of living a life of purpose and service. The poet, Tagore, whose work often carries a deep spiritual and philosophical message, suggests that doing good deeds and helping others is the way to earn a better future. The poem is a verbal question: here, the poet asks the reader to reflect on their life and the future, together with the future, together with the future, together with the future, so shall you reap'.

s readers whether they t is up to each person d plan accordingly for a n as the 'people's poet', a verbal question: here, s the future, together with the future, together with the future, so shall you reap'.

Theme

The poem carries the theme that as you sow, so shall you reap: doing good to others brings good in return. The poet poses a number of probing questions about how readers spend their days, with the major theme being that one should consider one's actions and deeds carefully and plan accordingly for a better future.

Poetic Style

This is an inspirational poem in which the repetition of questions emphasises its central saying. It attracts readers through simple language and an optimistic tone of writing, with four stanzas, each a quatrain of four lines.

Language and Poetic Devices

Interrogation and alliteration are the dominant figures of speech used in the poem, which follows a regular rhyme scheme of a, a, b, b.

Special Features

- Questions asked by the poet in lines 1, 2 and 4 of each stanza
- An optimistic tone throughout
- A reflective form that mirrors the poet's own thoughts

Message

- One should consider one's deeds and actions carefully and plan accordingly for a better future.
- Today's actions decide tomorrow.
- As you sow, so shall
- Service to man is se

Opinion

This is a genuinely in
tomorrow, and is well w

deeds decide a better

2.5 Father Returning Home, by Dilip Chitre

Summary

The poem reflects on the life of an ageing father who is alienated and disconnected from his family and society. It describes his monotonous daily routine, marked by loneliness and a lack of emotional connection. The father is a symbol of the older generation in a rapidly changing, urbanised world where personal bonds often take a backseat. Through vivid imagery and introspection, the poet portrays the father's inner turmoil, his alienation, and the emotional neglect he faces from his family.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*My father travels on the late evening train,
Standing among silent commuters in the yellow light.
Suburbs slide past his unseeing eyes
His shirt and pants are soggy, and his black raincoat
Stained with mud and his bag stuffed with books
Is falling apart. His eyes dimmed by age
Fade homeward through the humid monsoon night.*

- The father travels on a late train, surrounded by silent, indifferent commuters; the "yellow light" symbolises monotony and gloom.
- His gaze is described as "unseeing", indicating his lack of engagement with the world, while his soggy clothes and mud-stained raincoat suggest a life of hardship and detachment, with the
- The image of his "falling apart" raincoat and the "humid monsoon" setting add to the sense of his isolation and the passage of time.

Stanza 2

*Now I can see him get
Like a word dropped from a train
He hurries across the platform
Crosses the railway line
His chappals are sticky*

- His act of disembarking from the train is described as being "like a word dropped from a train", highlighting his insignificance in a larger world.
- He moves hurriedly to catch the train, suggesting discomfort, haste, and a life of constant movement and struggle.
- His "sticky chappals" symbolise his life's challenges and the wear of his journey.

Stanza 3

*Home again, I see him
Reading a book, fallen
On the floor, his head
On his open book*

*I often wonder if he retains his old dreams
From his boyhood, and the sense of loss he feels
At having missed them. He goes into the toilet
To contemplate man's estrangement from a man-made world.*

- His routine at home is marked by mediocrity and neglect; drinking "weak tea" and eating a "stale chapatti" reflect his marginalised position in the household.
- The poet wonders about his father's unfulfilled dreams and the emotional loss he carries.
- The father retreats to the toilet, symbolising his solitude and his effort to reflect on human estrangement in a world devoid of empathy.

Stanza 4

*Coming out he trembles at the sink,
The cold water running over his brown hands,
A few droplets cling to the greying hair on his wrists.
His sullen children have often refused to share
Jokes and secrets with him.
He will now go to sleep
Listening to the static on the radio, dreaming
Of his ancestors and grandchildren, thinking
Of nomads entering a subcontinent through a narrow pass.*

- His trembling at the sink and the cold water over his "brown hands" reflect his physical fatigue and the weathering of years of labour.
- The "greying hair" o droplets suggest the
- His "sullen children" I alienation and lack of
- Listening to "static o eaningful interaction,
- His dreams of "ance eage, the past and the
- The imagery of "nom igration and
- displacement, reflect ansitions and the
- struggles he has fac

Poetic Appreciation

Title of the Poem

The title 'Father Return hinting at how a father r

m. It is also suggestive,

About the Poet and the Poem

The poet, Dilip Chitre, was a well-known Indian English poet and translator who also contributed to painting, film-making and columns, and received the Sahitya Akademi Award for his translation work 'Says Tuka'. This poem draws a portrait of a suburban commuter: the father is a typical middle-class person with a dull, monotonous, exhausting and pitiable daily routine, and the poem describes his forced alienation even at home.

Language and Style

The poem is reflective in style, portraying the plight of a middle-class suburban commuter through symbolic words like 'yellow light' and 'grey platform'. Its language is a typical instance of Indian English, and its prosaic, simple line structure aptly reflects the father's simple, middle-class lifestyle.

Poetic Devices

Written in free verse, the poem is full of figures of speech, including simile ("Now I can see him getting off the train / Like a word dropped from a long sentence"), alliteration ("Suburbs slide past his unseeing eyes"), onomatopoeia (words like 'soggy' and 'cling') and transferred epithet ("fade homeward through the humid monsoon night").

Special Features

This is a typical poem depicting Indian middle-class lifestyle. Striking imagery, such as the 'grey platform', 'father drinking weak tea' and 'father eating a stale chapatti', along with the children's refusal to share their joys and sorrows with their hardworking father, the father's painful loneliness, and his neglected basic needs, make the poem

Message

- The poem makes us Indian middle-class f
- It indirectly teaches
- It also teaches us to

xperienced by an

ct them.

s.

Opinion

The poem depicts the families and culture, wh

ed especially to Indian those close to us.

2.6 Money, by William H. Davies

Summary

The poem critiques the obsession with wealth and its impact on human relationships. Davies reflects on the paradoxical nature of money: while it can bring comfort, it also breeds greed, jealousy and superficiality. The poet emphasises that true happiness lies in simplicity and meaningful relationships rather than material wealth.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*When I had money, money, O!
I knew no joy till I went poor;
For many a false man as a friend
Came knocking all day at my door.*

- The poet reflects on his past wealth, admitting that money did not bring true joy; happiness came only after losing wealth.
- He laments how money attracted false friends who sought him only for material gain, the repeated use of "money" emphasising its overpowering presence.

Stanza 2

*Then felt I like a child that holds
A trumpet that he mus
Because a man is dea
Not speak to let this fa*

- The poet compares imposed restrictions
- He avoided revealin materialistic nature.

Stanza 3

*Much have I thought o
How poor men's heart
And how their wives d
About their work from*

- The poet contrasts t fosters happiness.
- The imagery of wive meaningful relations

Stanza 4

*So, when I hear these poor ones laugh,
And see the rich ones coldly frown,
Poor men, think I, need not go up
So much as rich men should come down.*

- The poet observes the contrast between the cheerful laughter of the poor and the cold indifference of the rich.
- He concludes that the rich should abandon their arrogance and adopt the humility of the poor, emphasising the value of genuine human connection over material wealth.

Stanza 5

*When I had money, money, O!
My many friends proved all untrue;
But now I have no money, O!
My friends are real, though very few.*

- This stanza explores how money impacts friendships: when the speaker was wealthy, he was surrounded by many friends, but their loyalty proved false.
- After losing his wealth, most of these so-called friends disappeared, leaving him with only a small number of genuine companions, showing that true friends remain even in times of difficulty and highlighting the value of authenticity over material wealth.

Poetic Appreciation

About the Poem, Poe

The poem 'Money' tells when we do not have that though he no lon Davies, was born in Ne place to place as a tra peddler and street sin Poems'. The title is apt the world.

Theme

As shown in the title, m life; it is just a means t while losing it causes p

al happiness; it is only the end, the poet says . The poet, William H. d jobless, moving from efore later becoming a Destroyer and Other importance of money in

ney is not everything in ngs many false friends,

Poetic Style

The poem is reflective, drawing on the poet's own life experience, and is written in simple, easy-to-understand language, with a rhyme scheme of a, b, c, b.

Language and Poetic Devices

The poem uses figures of speech like inversion, antithesis and simile.

Special Features

- Generous use of figures of speech throughout
- The central irony: the poet having many friends when wealthy, but only a few genuine ones when penniless
- Vivid imagery, such as 'many a false man as a friend / Came knocking all day at my door' and 'felt I like a child that holds a trumpet'
- The antithetic use of words like 'poor-rich' and 'many-few'

Message

- Money is just a means to live, not a goal to be achieved.
- Money cannot give us real happiness.
- Money may buy many things, but it cannot be everything in life.
- Many friends may gather around us simply because we have money; they are loyal to the money, not to us.
- We must differentiate
- We can be happier

Opinion

The poem gives us a re
teaches us to identify a
the journey of one's life.

essary importance, and
most as a lighthouse in

2.7 She Walks in Beauty, by Lord Byron

Summary

"She Walks in Beauty" by Lord Byron is a lyrical poem that admires the physical and inner beauty of a woman. The poet compares her beauty to various natural elements, portraying her as an epitome of grace, elegance and purity. The poem explores the harmony between external appearance and inner goodness, emphasising that her beauty is not only visual but also moral and spiritual, celebrating beauty in its most idealised form, both external and internal.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*She walks in beauty, like the night
Of cloudless climes and starry skies;
And all that's best of dark and bright
Meet in her aspect and her eyes:
Thus mellowed to that tender light
Which heaven to gaudy day denies.*

- "She walks in beauty, like the night": the poet describes the woman's walk as graceful and serene, comparing it to the calm beauty of the night.
- The comparison to "cloudless climes and starry skies" evokes peace, purity and perfection, suggesting her beauty is both elegant and mysterious.
- "And all that's best of dark and bright": The poet suggests that the woman's beauty is a perfect balance of darkness (mystery, depth) and light (clarity, beauty).
- "Meet in her aspect and her eyes": The poet suggests that the woman's beauty is not just her physical features but also her inner qualities (grace, elegance, purity) and demeanour, not just what she looks like but how she carries herself.
- The final line contrasts the woman's beauty with the "gaudy day", suggesting that her beauty is more refined and serene and delicate, not just visually appealing but also morally and spiritually uplifting.

Stanza 2

*One shade the more,
Had half impaired the
Which waves in every
Or softly lightens o'er
Where thoughts serenely
How pure, how dear the*

- "One shade the more, Had half impaired the": The poet suggests that even a small change (a "shade") in the woman's beauty would diminish its perfection. This line emphasizes the uniqueness and ideal nature of her beauty.
- Her "raven tress" (dark hair) is described as "softly lightens o'er", suggesting a soft glow or radiance that evokes mystery and elegance.

- "Or softly lightens o'er her face" suggests that her beauty lies not just in her features but in the softness of her expression, as if light gently illuminates her face.
- The closing lines connect her external beauty to her inner nature: her peaceful demeanour reveals the purity of her thoughts, implying that her outward beauty reflects moral and spiritual goodness.

Stanza 3

*And on that cheek, and o'er that brow,
So soft, so calm, yet eloquent,
The smiles that win, the tints that glow,
But tell of days in goodness spent,
A mind at peace with all below,
A heart whose love is innocent!*

- In this stanza, Byron admires both the woman's beauty and her inner virtue.
- Her serene face reflects calmness and eloquence, while her enchanting smile and glowing complexion symbolise a life filled with goodness.
- Her peaceful mind and pure, innocent heart further highlight her genuine, virtuous nature, blending external charm with moral perfection.

Poetic Appreciation

About the Poem, Poet and Title

'She Walks in Beauty' is a short lyrical poem celebrating female beauty, describing an unnamed woman who is exceptionally striking. It was written by Lord Byron (1788-1824), known as Lord Byron, whose work 'Childe Harold's Pilgrimage' made him famous. The poem indirectly suggests the woman's beauty and inner virtue.

Theme

This famous poem by Byron is striking. It praises and celebrates the woman's expression. The speaker describes a harmonious meeting between the woman's external beauty and her inner virtue.

t, who is exceptionally beautiful. The theme of love and its expression is conveyed through her beauty as a symbol of inner virtue.

Poetic Style

As a love poem, it is written in iambic pentameter. It includes similes (comparing her beauty to a clear, starry sky), antithesis ("An angel's face and a demon's smile"), and a regular rhyme scheme.

to praise the woman's beauty and inner virtue. The poem uses various poetic devices like similes, antithesis, and a regular rhyme scheme to convey its message.

Special Features

The poem depicts the woman's external beauty at the beginning and her inner goodness by the end, making it a complete circle of art depicting both human beauty and goodness.

Message

The poem conveys that beauty and love are virtues much valued and adored in human life, and are an integral part of it.

Opinion

The poem is appreciated as a love poem and for its allied aspects, being a perfect blend of beauty and harmony of mind and body.

2.8 Small Towns and Rivers, by Mamang Dai

Summary

The poem reflects the poet's deep connection to her homeland, focusing on the small towns and rivers that are integral to her identity. Through vivid imagery and a nostalgic tone, Mamang Dai portrays the timelessness of these places and their cultural and emotional significance. The poem explores the themes of transience, continuity and the interconnectedness of life, and also highlights the coexistence of tradition and modernity, along with the spiritual essence of rivers as carriers of history and memory.

Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

*Small towns always remind me of death.
My hometown lies calmly amidst the trees,
it is always the same,
in summer or winter,
with the dust flying,
or the wind howling down the gorge.
Just the other day someone died.
In the dreadful silence we wept
looking at the sad wreath of tuberose.
Life and death, life and death,
only the rituals are per*

- The speaker associates nature, where life and death coexist.
- The hometown is depicted as a place of timelessness, with nature (dust flying, winds howling) creating a sense of continuity.
- The mention of someone dying and the traditional "wreath of tuberose" symbolizes the passage of time and the enduring nature of life and death.
- The repetition of "life and death" emphasizes the cyclical nature of existence, where change is constant, yet the rituals remain unchanged.

ced, unchanging
with nature (dust flying,
winds howling) creating
through the passage of
change, the rituals,

Stanza 2

*The river has a soul.
In the summer it cuts through
like a torrent of grief. Sometimes,
I think it has a*

*seeking a land of fish and stars.
The river has a soul.*

- The river is personified as having a soul, embodying emotion, memory and life rather than being just a physical entity.
- In summer it is described as forceful, cutting through the land "like a torrent of grief", possibly symbolising the heaviness of loss or the sorrow of passing time.
- The river seeming to "hold its breath" suggests it is waiting or yearning for something ethereal, a "land of fish and stars", blending the natural world with cosmic longing.
- The repetition of "The river has a soul" reinforces the centrality of the river as a symbol of the eternal flow of life and emotion.

Stanza 3

*It knows, stretching past the town,
from the first drop of rain to dry earth
and mist on the mountaintops,
the river knows
the immortality of water.*

- The river is portrayed as knowing and understanding the journey from the first drop of rain to the dry earth, capturing the cycle of life.
- The mist on the mountaintops connects the river's journey to the greater natural world, symbolising both its origin and destination.
- The river's knowledge of being constantly recycled through nature

Stanza 4

*A shrine of happy pictures
marks the days of childhood
Small towns grow with
for the future.
The dead are placed pictures
When the soul rises
it will walk into the pictures
into the house of the soul*

- The "shrine of happy pictures" marks the days of childhood, marking the passage of time.
- Small towns are described as growing with the future, despite the calm of the river.
- The dead being buried in pictures, the soul's rise into the "pictures" represents transcendence, an idea that connects the end of life, while the soul moves toward rebirth or

Stanza 5

*In the cool bamboo,
restored in sunlight,
life matters, like this.*

- The "cool bamboo" symbolises peace, nature and calmness, a place of reflection and restoration; being "restored in sunlight" represents healing and renewal.
- The phrase "life matters, like this" emphasises that life's true essence lies in simple, serene moments, in harmony with nature and the beauty of small-town life.

Stanza 6

*In small towns by the river
we all want to walk with the gods.*

- The closing lines capture the spiritual yearning of people living in small towns, where the river serves as a metaphor for connection to the divine, the natural world and the afterlife.
- In their humble surroundings, people long for a transcendent experience, symbolised by the desire "to walk with the gods", a deeper connection with the universe or divine forces.

Poetic Appreciation

About the Poem and the Title

The poem depicts the landscape and nature of the poetess's hometown, Pasighat, and the eternity of natural elements. It is b
ones continue to dwell
in the natural elements
lated to the theme, and
one can guess the subj

About the Poetess

The poem is written by
Itanagar, Arunachal Pra
journalist, is an enviro
connection with nature
Sahitya Akademi Award

former civil servant from
an active radio and TV
icted tribal life and its
a Shri (2011) and the

Theme

The poem depicts the
recurring presence and

he river is a dominant,

Poetic Style

The poetess expresses
prosaic way that makes

hometown in a simple,

Language and Poetic Devices

The language is simple and lucid, describing the landscape in a prosaic style. The effective use of free verse, along with vivid figures of speech like simile, metaphor, transferred epithet and antithesis, makes the poem more beautiful.

Special Features

- Effective use of free verse to depict nature
- Depicts the life and traditions of Arunachal Pradesh and the tribal community 'Adi'
- Carries a message about protecting nature against the development of small towns

Message

The poem laments the loss of nature to development. The poet's love for nature gives us a direct message to love and protect our mother earth, which offers us all its treasures; it is up to us how respectfully we accept that gift.

Opinion

The poem is appreciated for its simple, lucid language, depicting the nature of the poetess's hometown and the beliefs of the 'Adi' community. Her concern over the destruction of nature, the vivid imagery, and concepts like 'the river has a soul' and 'the river knows the immortality of water' make it a wonderfully crafted piece of work.